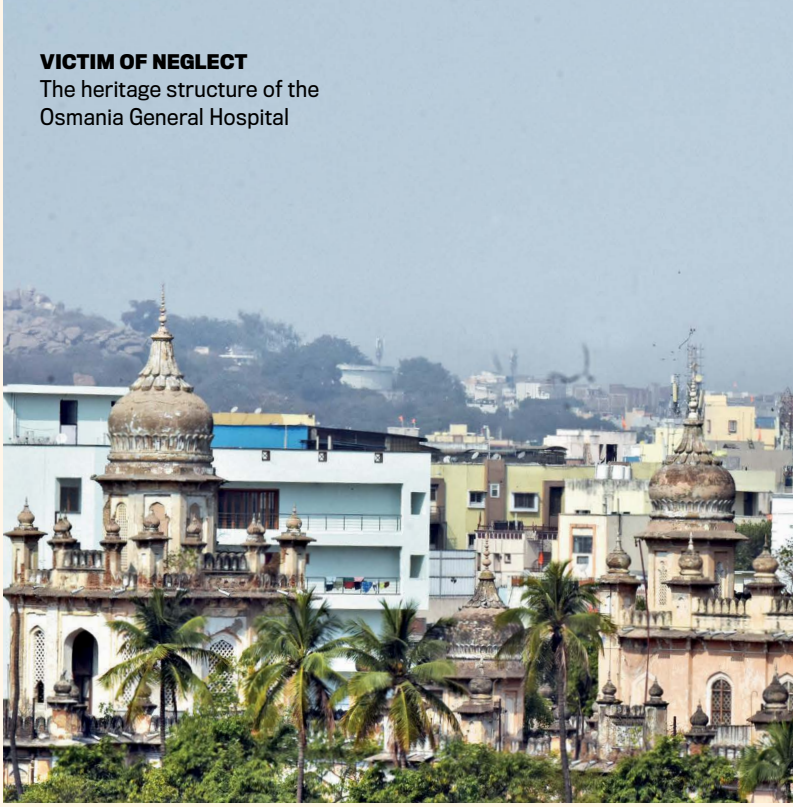
The grand event was first ideated by the state's Heritage Cabinet in 2017. Odisha is the only state in the country to have set up such a cabinet to protect ancient monuments, temples and archaeological sites, and take steps to preserve the state's culture, language and literature. But the plan didn't see the light of day until 2024 for several reasons, one of them being the Covid pandemic. However, as Balakrishnan would put it, Odisha is a story of coming back and hence a seven-year wait couldn't deter the state's conviction to organise the event. "In 1895, the British tried to divide the people of Odisha by announcing that Hindi is the official language of our people. Major resistance erupted everywhere, leading to the first linguist agitation," he says, "In 1903, the Utkal Sammilani was founded by lawyer and social reformer Madhusudan Das to give impetus to the cause. Following this and other events, the state of Odisha was recognised in 1936."

A NEW KEYBOARD DEBUTED FOR CHILDREN TO FACILITATE THE USE OF ODIA IN DIGITAL FORMATS

To showcase the uniqueness, evolution and heritage of a language and culture that ticks at least a millennium on the calendar, three massive hangars were set up as part of a three-day exhibition following the conference, which portrayed the language's journey through various ages. The 1,982-foot-long exhibition-cum-museum area culminated in a gigantic dome-shaped structure, adorned with a huge Odia keyboard, robots and materials sourced from the Odisha Virtual Academy—an entity set up "to portray the past and present in front of the future generation to recognise and widespread Odia as a language of knowledge and science".

In 1879, a book on elementary physics was published in Odia in Cuttack. "Why are such attempts not made these days?" Balakrishnan asks. "To encourage this revival, we have to engage technology and the future generation. That is the target of this exhibition and the conference as a whole, because language, much like art and craft, is not a relic of the past. It is a living tradition." ■



VICTIM OF NEGLECT
The heritage structure of the Osmania General Hospital

HYDERABAD

AN ILL WIND OVER A CITY'S HERITAGE

By Amarnath K. Menon

If the courts do not rescue it from a perilous fate, Hyderabad could well bid adieu to what has been an integral part of the city's cultural and architectural heritage—the century-old original building of Osmania General Hospital (OGH). A gift by its last Nizam, Mir Osman Ali Khan, the plan to build the hospital was conceived after the deadly bubonic plague of 1911, even though it was completed and became operational only by 1925. Designed by the British architect Vincent J. Esch, a pioneer of the Indo-Saracenic style of architecture, the hospital was part of the city's 20th century skyline, which also included the High Court and City College. Now, the Qutb Shahi-style domed building, spread over three acres along the Musi river, faces demolition, to make way for a larger facility.

With over half a million patients, mostly from poor sections, visiting this government hospital annually, there is no denying the urgent need to expand the facilities at OGH. However, year after year, the previous K. Chandrashekar Rao-led Bharat Rashtra Samithi regime failed to make budgetary provisions for this